

Women's Speeches in Legislative Committees: A Feminist Institutionalism Explanation

Paolo Gambacciani*

Edoardo Alberto Viganò[†]

September 23, 2026

Abstract

Gender roles constrain and give meaning to legislators' behaviour. Yet we know little about how gender roles shape women's activities in legislative committees. By adopting a feminist institutionalism perspective, we show that committee speeches are gendered. Although men and women do not differ in their overall likelihood of speaking in committees, women are less likely to intervene and devote less speaking time to masculine issues. When comparing speaking activities between the floor and the committees, we find suggestive evidence that highly active women prioritise the floor to exploit the greater visibility of these discussions. Our analyses compare men and women debating the same legislative proposals using a unique dataset of speech participation in the Italian lower house between 2013 and 2022. Our results contribute to the literature on gender and legislative studies by showing that committees are not gender-neutral arenas, but key sites where informal norms shape women's parliamentary work.

Keywords: Gender; Feminist institutionalism; Legislative studies; Legislative speech.

*(paolo.gambacciani@unibo.it) - Department of Political and Social Sciences, University of Bologna, Bologna, Italy – ORCID: <https://orcid.org/0000-0001-6356-1081>

[†]University Carlos III of Madrid

Legislative behaviour is shaped not only by MPs' strategic motivations but also by institutional practices and informal norms. Many of these expectations are gendered and shape the parliamentary behaviour of men and women (Chappell 2006; Kenny 2007). Rooted in broader societal divisions of labour and authority (Schneider and Bos 2023), gendered expectations continue to position women as less legitimate political actors than men. Consequently, women participate less frequently in highly visible parliamentary activities, particularly debates on policy areas stereotypically associated with masculine expertise, such as defence, foreign affairs, and the economy (Bäck et al. 2014). The inequalities created by gender norms are reinforced by institutional arrangements that grant party leaders substantial discretion over access to politically valuable activities, including plenary speaking opportunities (Anzia and Berry 2011; Clayton and Zetterberg 2021), and offices, such as prestigious committee assignments (Pansardi and Vercesi 2017). In the male-dominated environment of political parties (O'Brien 2015), such discretion makes allocation decisions susceptible to gendered evaluations of competence and credibility. Yet these hierarchies are not immutable, and highly specialised women may leverage particularly visible parliamentary activities to phase out existing norms (Josefsson 2024) and defend women's interests (Childs and Krook 2009).

Although the consequences of gendered norms have been widely documented across different parliamentary settings (Lawless 2015), it remains unclear how far they extend. Notably, it is unknown whether they operate in parliamentary committees (for an exception, see Funk et al. (2017)), which are arenas mainly governed by informal rules and practices (Matthews 1960; Waylen 2014). This gap is important because existing accounts of gendered participation in plenary debates point to two analytically distinct mechanisms. On the one hand, lower levels of female participation may reflect constraints imposed by party leaders over access to scarce speaking opportunities. On the other hand, they may reflect gendered norms that shape legislators' own sense of entitlement to speak, partic-

ularly on policy areas coded as masculine (Bäck et al. 2014; Waylen 2014). By adopting a feminist institutionalist perspective, according to which legislative behaviour is shaped by gender roles and members' strategies (Chappell 2006; Mackay et al. 2010), we examine committee speeches, which, unlike floor speeches, are less directly controlled by party leaders (Proksch and Slapin 2012). To address these issues, we ask three related questions. Do men and women differ in their overall likelihood of speaking in committees? Do gender differences in committees vary according to whether bills concern masculine-coded or feminine-coded issues? Among MPs who speak, do women and men allocate their speaking activity differently between committees and the floor, especially when debating masculine-coded bills?

To answer these questions, we rely on an original MP–bill dataset of speeches in the Italian lower house between 2013 and 2022. We focus on Italy because it combines gendered patterns in political recruitment (Belluati et al. 2020) with a suitable institutional setting, in which party leaders heavily influence access to plenary speech and committee speeches are less formally constrained (Capano and Giuliani 2001; Giannetti et al. 2016). By using bill fixed effects, we compare men and women debating the same legislative proposal and assess whether gender differences vary across issue type and venue. Using the committee referral of each bill, we classify legislative proposals into masculine, feminine, and other issues.

Our results, which are robust across different classification methods, indicate that women's committee speeches are gendered. The gender gap in participation that is observed the floor disappears in committees: men and women do not differ significantly in their overall likelihood of speaking in this venue. Yet, even in this relatively unconstrained environment, women are less likely than men to participate in debates on masculine issues. Moreover, while women's higher participation in feminine-coded debates largely reflects patterns of pre-parliamentary specialisation, their lower participation in

masculine-coded debates does not. We only find weak support for the argument that gender also conditions venue choice. While we do not find a significant overall effect, the group of women who intervene more often on a bill devote more time to speaking on the floor than men do. We interpret these results as evidence of a gendered institution. Women feel less entitled to speak on masculine issues even where party leaders exercise little control over access to debate, and the formal gatekeeping powers that leaders hold on the floor can amplify, rather than create, these inequalities. By theorising and empirically testing the extent of gender norms in legislative committees, this study shows that committees are not gender-neutral arenas, but key sites where informal norms shape women's parliamentary work.

Theoretical framework

Legislative studies typically conceptualise parliamentary behaviour as the outcome of the interaction between MPs' goals and institutional constraints (Martin et al. 2014). Electoral institutions, party nomination rules, rules of procedure, agenda-setting powers, and the distribution of offices all shape what MPs can do and which strategies are available to them (Strøm 1997). Yet formal institutions alone cannot fully explain legislators' behaviour. Actors who enjoy the same rights within the same institution often behave differently, suggesting that parliamentary behaviour is also shaped by less visible norms, routines, and expectations (Matthews 1960; Searing 1994).

Neo-institutionalist approaches address this limitation by treating institutions not only as formal constraints but also as sets of roles, norms, routines, and shared expectations embedded in political life (March and Olsen 1989). Within this framework, feminist institutionalism theorises a gendered logic of appropriateness, according to which expectations about suitable parliamentary behaviour are shaped by informal gender roles (Chap-

pell 2006). This framework has proved useful for explaining patterns of parliamentary behaviour that formal rules cannot fully account for, such as why women may speak less on masculine-coded issues despite having the same formal right to intervene (Bäck et al. 2014), or why they may feel stronger pressure to prove their competence and reliability through parliamentary activity (Butler et al. 2022; Pearson and Dancey 2011b).

Because gendered roles are embedded in the parliamentary institution as a whole, they shape both men and women MPs' legislative behaviour. Following sociological role theory (Bates 2021), these roles would generate norms that affect both women's perceptions of when their participation is legitimate and valuable and the ways in which their interventions are evaluated by others – i.e., as political outsiders whose competence and authority are more readily questioned (Puwar 2004). Through this role-based lens, the masculine blueprint of legislatures may also enable male actors to reproduce practices that weaken women's authority (Schneider and Bos 2023) and preserve institutional arrangements that protect their access to scarce parliamentary resources (Heath et al. 2005; Josefsson 2024; Pansardi and Vercesi 2017).

The effects of these gendered norms, however, should vary across venues. Gender inequalities should be stronger where party leaders can reinforce informal expectations through formal rules that regulate access to parliamentary activities (Josefsson 2024). Conversely, they should be weaker in arenas where leaders have fewer instruments to control participation directly. In this sense, comparing how the same activity is performed on the parliamentary floor and in legislative committees provides a useful contrast, since committee activities are governed more extensively by informal rules and practices (Matthews 1960; Waylen 2014).

Although several activities – such as parliamentary questions and bill amendments – can be undertaken in both venues, parliamentary speechmaking provides a particularly suitable setting for examining this variation because access to speaking opportuni-

ties differs across the two arenas. Speechmaking provides a particularly suitable setting for examining variation in party control because access to speaking opportunities differs sharply across the plenary and legislative committees. On the floor, especially in party-centred environments, speechmaking is subject to party gatekeeping. Speaking time is allocated through formal procedures, and party leaders exercise substantial discretion over speaker selection (Proksch and Slapin 2012). In committees, by contrast, access to speech is not constrained by the same formal gatekeeping mechanisms. MPs have more freedom to decide whether to intervene, as participation depends on committee-specific practices and informal bargaining (Ban et al. 2022; Capano and Giuliani 2001; Funk et al. 2017; Yin 2024).¹

This difference in how speechmaking is governed reflects the distinct functions of speechmaking in the two venues. Floor speeches are highly visible to voters and allow MPs to claim credit, take public positions, and advertise their activities to constituents (Mayhew 1974). They also serve parties' collective goals, including agenda-setting, issue competition, and the communication of a coherent party message (Giannetti et al. 2016; Ivanusch 2023). Because floor time is both scarce and politically valuable, party leaders have strong incentives to reserve speaking opportunities for MPs perceived as credible on the issue under debate (Fernandes et al. 2019) and aligned with the party line (Giannetti and Pedrazzani 2016). Committee debates, in contrast, are less visible to voters, and parties therefore have weaker incentives to control participation as tightly as they do on the floor (Chaqués-Bonafont and Cristancho 2022).

Given the different functions of floor and committee speeches, we expect gendered role expectations to matter more strongly on the floor, where speeches are more visible,

¹We acknowledge that parties exert control over committee assignments, which are themselves gendered (Pansardi and Vercesi 2017). Yet assignments constrain where MPs sit, not who may speak: in the case we study, any MP can ask to intervene in any committee debate, regardless of the committee to which they belong (see below).

and access is more directly controlled by party leaders. By contrast, because committee participation is less visible and less directly shaped by formal party gatekeeping, we do not expect women to be generally less likely than men to speak in committee debates.

H1 *Women MPs are equally likely as men MPs to speak in committee debates.*

The absence of an overall gender gap in committee participation would not imply that committee speechmaking is unaffected by gendered norms. While committee debates create fewer constraints on women's participation, parliamentary behaviour remains embedded in informal expectations that define which actors are perceived as legitimate participants in particular policy areas (Chappell 2006; Kenny 2007). Crucially, these expectations vary across policy domains. Defence, security, finance, and economic policy are commonly associated with masculine stereotypes emphasising technical expertise, leadership, and authority, whereas health, education, and social welfare are more often linked to feminine traits related to care. Even where women are free to intervene, a gendered logic of appropriateness may therefore continue to steer men and women towards different debates.

This argument is consistent with research showing that female MPs are less likely to participate in plenary debates on masculine-coded issues, while gender differences narrow or even reverse on feminine-coded ones (Bäck and Debus 2019; Catalano 2009; Curini et al. 2024). Similar patterns characterise committee assignments, where women remain underrepresented in influential, masculine-coded committees and concentrated in those dealing with social and care-related policies (Heath et al. 2005; Kroeber 2024; Murray and Sénac 2018). Our resulting expectation is therefore that issue-specific gaps should persist even in the absence of an overall gender gap in speech.

H2 *Conditional on participating in committee debates, women MPs are less likely than men MPs*

to intervene on masculine-coded bills and more likely to intervene on feminine-coded bills.

The previous hypotheses concern whether women participate in committee debates and whether their participation differs across policy domains. We now turn to a different question: how women distribute their parliamentary speech across institutional venues. Specifically, we explore whether women who intervene on masculine-coded issues are more likely to do so in committees or on the floor. This is important because women may use the greater visibility of floor discussions to challenge the current view that women are less qualified than men to debate masculine issues. Indeed, feminist institutionalism treats agency as strategic: actors operate within institutional constraints, but they can also exploit available opportunities to challenge existing arrangements (Driscoll and Krook 2009; Josefsson 2024; Mackay et al. 2010; Waylen 2014).

Building upon what we theorised in H2, according to which women would be more reluctant to speak about masculine issues regardless of party control, we expect that such institutional change is promoted by a small number of particularly motivated legislators (Childs and Krook 2009). In particular, women MPs can use their voices on the floor to make the parliament a less gendered institution. Through their speeches on masculine issues, they would attempt to weaken the taboo surrounding women's participation in parliamentary activities, which in turn could lead other women to feel less pressure to demonstrate that they are at least as competent as their male colleagues when they intervene on the floor (Anzia and Berry 2011; Kanter 1977; Pearson and Dancey 2011a). This interpretation is also consistent with evidence that women MPs adopt a distinctive form of communication when they are underrepresented within their political group to advocate for women's interests (Curini et al. 2024).

Although party leaders may constrain women's ability to access plenary speaking time in order to keep parliament a male-dominated institution, where women are un-

derrepresented and discriminated against (Anzia and Berry 2011; Kanter 1977; Pearson and Dancey 2011b), we expect women MPs to be more likely than men to allocate their interventions on masculine-coded issues to the plenary.

H3 *Among MPs who speak, women allocate a larger share of their intervention on masculine-coded issues to plenary relative to committee debates.*

Case study, research design and data

The Italian case

The Italian lower house (*Camera dei Deputati*) is a suitable case for examining how gendered norms influence women's speech in committee settings. Italy's landscape is marked by persistent gender biases embedded in Italian society, culture, and media (Belluati et al. 2020). These biases involve not only the private job recruitment processes and women's daily life, but also politics and public institutions. Although women's parliamentary representation has grown over time, reaching the 30 per cent threshold over the past 15 years (Pansardi and Pinto 2020; Pansardi and Vercesi 2017), the Italian parliament is still affected by gendered norms. As a result, in plenary sessions, when a masculine issue is addressed on the floor, women intervene less often, and the overall parliamentary attention to female issues is limited (Cavalieri and De Giorgi 2025; Curini et al. 2024). Notably, the time dedicated to bills or other acts in defence of women's rights is scarce even in the current term, with Italy's first female Prime Minister (Cavalieri and De Giorgi 2025). When considering formal rules, the pattern is likewise gendered, as party leaders leverage standing orders and party nominee rules to obstruct women's access to candidacies and prestigious committee assignments (Pansardi and Pedrazzani 2023; Pansardi and Pinto

2020; Pansardi and Vercesi 2017).

Overall, these pieces of evidence suggest the existence of gender stereotypes in the Italian Parliament. This gendered context is facilitated by the Italian institutional setting, which ensures that party leaders exercise strong control over bill approvals in plenary sessions (Giannetti and Pedrazzani 2016).² Specifically, for speaking time on the floor, the standing order provides that speaking time devoted to any discussion on the floor is split among parliamentary groups on a monthly basis, according to the deliberations of the conference of party whips (*Conferenza dei Capigruppo*). As a result of this deliberation, each group receives a specific amount of time for any bill discussed on the floor, based on its size, the topic, and the type of bill being examined.³ This time is directly managed by the party group leadership, which grants or denies speaking opportunities to its members who request them. As a result of these formal rules, party gatekeepers have the power to select the speaker deemed most appropriate for any discussion, potentially denying women's access to masculine issues (Curini et al. 2024).

In contrast, discussions of legislative bills in the committee venue are less constrained by formal rules. For the Italian standing orders, each bill, before being discussed and voted on the floor, is assigned by the house speaker to one of the permanent committees according to the main issue it covers. In the event of overlapping competencies between two committees, the chair may assign the bill to two permanent committees. During this

²According to the Italian constitution, Italy is a bicameral parliamentary system, under which a proposal to become law must be approved in the same version by both the upper and lower house. Typically, bill examination, especially when presented by the government, is analysed only by the first house in which the bill is first presented, as the second house, whether upper or lower, ratifies within a few days without amendments (i.e., "*monocameralismo di fatto*") (Gianniti and Lupo 2023; Lasorella 2023). In the first house, the time dedicated to the committee examination ranges from 30 to 60 days, depending on whether the bill is a decree-law or an ordinary bill, while the time reserved for floor discussion is typically no longer than 7 days (Lasorella 2023).

³Some additional flexibility is granted to members when debates revolve around decree-laws, constitutional law, electoral laws, or budget law, allowing opposition parties more time to intervene (Giannetti and Pedrazzani 2016). Similar prerogatives exist for interventions at the end of each session (*interventi di fine seduta*) or against the party line during roll-call debates (*interventi in dissenso*).

period, the permanent committees responsible for the bill can hold auditions or ask the opinion (*parere*) of other permanent committees. Whether a bill involves budget expenditures, the public labor market, or any constitutional article, the Committee must obtain the opinions of the Committee on Constitutional Affairs (first committee), Budget (fifth committee), and Labor (eleventh committee). Each committee opinion is presented by the bill rapporteur when the bill is discussed on the floor.

In this context of bill discussions in permanent committees, the possibility of speaking in this venue on a bill is mainly unconstrained. The only constraint could be the time deadline set by the floor or committee agenda (*programma dei lavori*) for examining and approving the bill. Within this time, MPs who want to speak must simply catch the Committee Chair's attention by asking to intervene on the bill under examination (Lasorella 2023). Most importantly, any MP for any committee discussion, regardless of the committee in which it was appointed, can ask to participate and speak in the debate (see articles 19, 38, 80, and 86 of the lower house standing order). Consequently, a woman assigned to the Education or Social Affairs Committee (seventh and twelfth Committees) can still participate in a debate in the Defense Committee when, for example, the Minister of Defense is heard or when the committee examines a bill on military expenditures.

This contrasting scenario on speaking rules and practices between floor and committees is well-suited to our research hypotheses because it allows us to examine whether women's lower involvement in parliamentary discussions on masculine topics depends on party gatekeeping power or on gendered informal norms. Furthermore, because the house speaker assigns bills to committees competent by subject matter, committee referral is an institutionally grounded indicator of each bill's dominant policy domain, capable of individuating the main issue covered by any bill.

Data, variables, and model estimation

To test our arguments, we employ data on lower house speech participation in committees and plenary between 2013 and 2022 (17th and 18th legislative terms). We sourced all our data from the open data of the Italian lower house.⁴ Speech data are linked to the corresponding bill, and, given our focus on legislative speeches, we restrict attention to debates concerning a bill which have been discussed on the floor at least one time. We exclude speeches by house speakers and vice speakers, MPs who did not serve the full legislative term, and legislators who started their term without an affiliation to any party group. We focus on speech participation and not (also) on speech content due to data availability: while full transcripts of plenary speeches are available, committee speeches are only published as few-line summaries.

In the main model specifications (see below), we leverage an MP-bill dataset in which the unit of observation is an MP's speech-making behaviour for a given bill, in both the plenary and committees. We operationalise speech-making in two ways. First, we employ a participation indicator coded 1 if an MP delivered at least one speech during debate on a bill and 0 otherwise. This measure captures the extensive margin of participation by distinguishing MPs who contribute to a debate from those who remain silent. Second, among MPs who participated, we use a count variable measuring the number of speeches delivered on the bill. This measure captures variation in the intensity of speech-making, conditional on participation. Both variables are computed separately for plenary and committee debates. While we do not have distinct theoretical expectations for these two operationalisations, reporting both allows us to examine complementary dimensions of legislative speech-making. To assess venue allocation (H3), the dependent variable is the proportion of an MP's speeches on a given bill that are delivered in the plenary. This measure is calculated as the number of plenary speeches divided by the total number

⁴<https://dati.camera.it/en>.

of speeches delivered across plenary and committee debates. Because the measure is less informative when based on a small number of speeches, we exclude MP–bill observations with fewer than three speeches.

The main independent variable is MPs’ gender. We code women MPs as 1 and men MPs as 0. To test H2 and H3, we interact gender with the issue discussed. In the lower house, the speaker assigns each bill to the committee(s) competent by subject matter. We classify bills using committee assignment into three categories: masculine, feminine, and other. Masculine-coded bills are those assigned to committees dealing with constitutional and home affairs, foreign affairs, defence, the budget, finance, and transport; feminine-coded bills are those assigned to education/culture and social affairs/health; all remaining bills are coded as other. In the rare cases of overlap due to multiple assignments, the masculine category takes precedence so that the classification remains mutually exclusive.⁵ While the literature offers no single agreed definition of masculine and feminine issues and committees, and operationalisations vary across studies (Espírito-Santo and Sanches 2020, p. 457), our classification follows Krook and O’Brien (2012) and Bäck and Debus (2019), as previous studies on Italy have done (Pansardi and Vercesi 2017).

In a series of robustness checks, we operationalise issue type using alternative classification schemes. First, we classify bills based on their titles using the Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) coding scheme. To assign CAP topics, we employ two independent large language model approaches: the CAP Babel fine-tuned XLM-RoBERTa model (Sebők et al. 2025) and Anthropic Claude Opus 4.8. Second, for the MP-level analyses, we classify issues according to the committee in which the parliamentary debate took place rather than the committee(s) to which the bill was referred. Tables A5–A7 report the mapping between CAP major topic codes and our issue-type categories, as well as the confusion matrices comparing committee referral with CAP-based coding. These alterna-

⁵The results are robust to the exclusion of debates in which the bill was assigned to multiple committees.

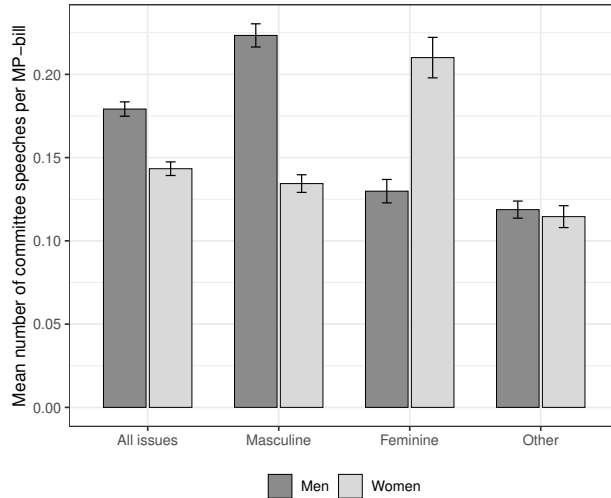


Figure 1. Average number of committee speeches by gender across issues.

tive operationalisations allow us to assess whether our findings are robust to different measures of issue type.

Figure 1 plots the average number of speeches per bill delivered by female and male MPs in committees. We observe that male legislators tend to deliver more speeches than female MPs. However, this unconditional comparison does not take into account that women tend to be more junior, to hold fewer legislative and party leadership positions, and to be assigned different committees than men. The breakdown of speeches by issue offers preliminary support for H2. The patterns for masculine and feminine issues are clearly different: men talk more than women when debates are masculine-coded, whereas the gap reverses on feminine-coded ones.

The models include a set of controls for individual characteristics that may affect MPs' speaking activity. At the individual level, we account for parliamentary experience (measured as the total number of terms served as an MP); party initial affiliation; party switching; age; education (measured by whether the MP holds a university degree); parliamentary office (including both legislative and party positions within the lower house); government office; election in a single-member district (SMD) of the majoritarian tier of the

mixed system; and vulnerability, computed following (André et al. 2015). We also control for the committee each MP served on for the longest period. This is important because MPs are more likely to speak on bills related to their committee assignments, which are distributed with a gendered pattern across issues that could in turn depend on parties' ideology (Pansardi and Vercesi 2017). Finally, we also include an indicator of whether the MP served as rapporteur for the bill. Table A1 reports the descriptive statistics for the variables used by our models.

In the main models, we leverage within-bill variation in speech-making behaviour. By including bill fixed effects, we compare men and women within the same bill, holding constant all bill-level characteristics that may affect the probability of speaking, such as salience, issue content, and the stage of the legislative process (i.e., whether the bill is assigned to the lower house at first or second reading). Regarding model choice, for the participation dummies (H1 and H2), we estimate logistic regressions; for the speech counts (H1 and H2), negative binomial regressions; and for H3, where the dependent variable is a proportion bounded between 0 and 1, a fractional logit. We employ two-way clustered standard errors at both the MP and the bill level. This accounts for the fact that observations are not independent. The same MP appears across multiple bills, creating potential correlation in speech-making behaviour within legislators. At the same time, multiple MPs are observed on the same bill and may therefore be affected by common bill-specific factors.

In the Appendix, we present descriptive statistics for our population. Our dataset consists of 3536 unique bills, with 3004 assigned to one committee and 518 assigned to two committees. The distribution of assignments across committees is not homogeneous, as bills are more frequently assigned to the Constitutional Affairs and the Justice committees.

Results

Figure 2 presents the estimates for committee access (whether an MP intervenes on a given bill) and intensity (the number of speeches delivered). Holding the bill under discussion constant, female MPs are no less likely than men to take the committee floor. The coefficient for female MPs is statistically indistinguishable from zero in both the access and intensity models, consistent with H1. These findings differ substantively from those for plenary speeches (reported in Table A2, which also reports the full committee models) where women are significantly less likely to speak than men. At first glance, therefore, legislative committees appear to provide a more gender-balanced environment for participation than the plenary.

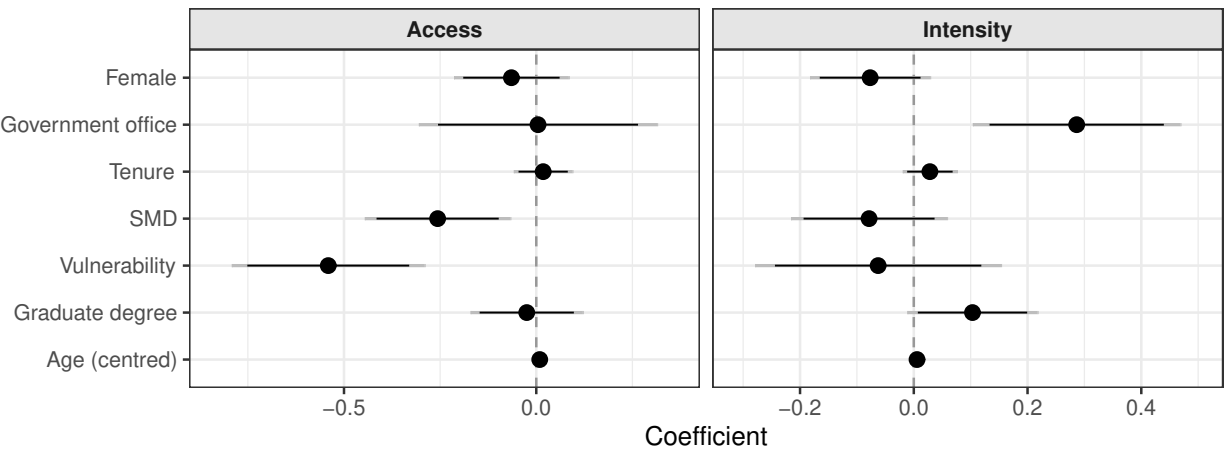


Figure 2. Gender and speeches in committees, 95% (grey)/90% (black) confidence intervals.

Yet aggregate measures of speech participation could mask heterogeneity across policy domains. H2 posits that a gender gap should emerge in debates on bills addressing gendered issue areas: women should be less likely than men to intervene on masculine-coded issues and more likely to do so on feminine-coded issues. Figure 3 reports the estimated effect of being a female legislator on both the probability of speaking and the

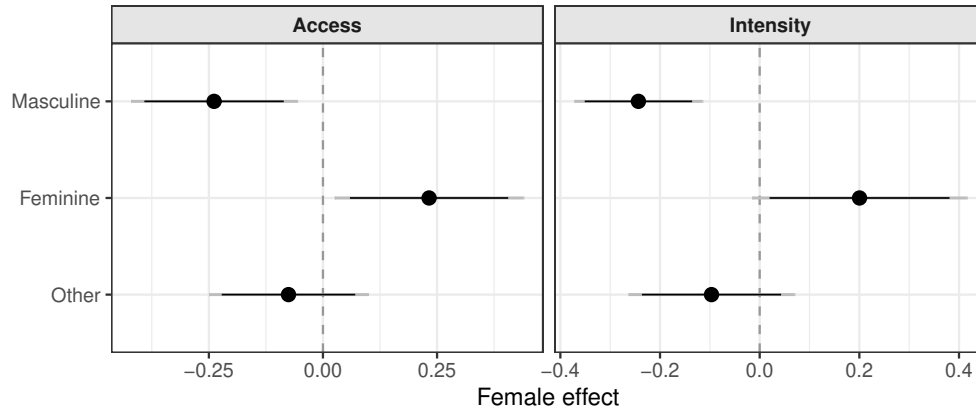


Figure 3. Total effect of gender on speeches in committees across issues, 95% (grey)/90% (black).

number of speeches delivered across issue types. The results support H2. Female MPs speak significantly less than male MPs on masculine-coded issues, but significantly more on feminine-coded issues. No statistically significant gender differences emerge for other policy areas. Thus, while women participate in committee debates as frequently as men overall, the persistence of these issue-specific gaps, which previous research has also documented in the plenary (Bäck and Debus 2019), suggests that women’s participation remains structured by the gendered content of the issues under discussion. This pattern is consistent with the argument that gendered expectations shape legislative behaviour even in institutional settings where gatekeeping is limited.

To further explore these findings, we distinguish between speeches delivered as committee members and as non-members. The former take place within an MP’s committee and are therefore shaped by committee internal roles. The latter reflects a less constrained form of participation, as legislators choose to intervene in committees to which they do not belong. [Figure A1](#) in the Appendix shows that the gendered pattern documented above is concentrated among committee members. Female members are significantly less likely than male members to intervene on masculine-coded bills and significantly more likely to speak on feminine-coded bills. By contrast, among non-members, the estimated

gender differences are substantially smaller and statistically indistinguishable from zero across issue types, at least in the access models. This asymmetry provides suggestive evidence that the issue gender gap is not driven primarily by women's policy interests. Instead, it points to the importance of informal roles and gendered expectations associated with committee assignments. An alternative interpretation is that participation by non-members is selective: women MPs who choose to speak in masculine committees outside their assignment might represent an atypical group of female legislators, characterised by high expertise in hard/masculine domains or willingness to challenge gender norms.

In addition, we also assess whether the empirical support for H1 and H2 depends on how issue domains are operationalised and on the level of aggregation of the dependent variable. In the baseline specification, issues are coded based on the referral committee associated with each bill. As a robustness check, we instead classify issue domains using the committee in which the speech took place. This alternative approach shifts the analysis to the MP level and models counts of speeches using negative binomial regressions, distinguishing masculine-coded, feminine-coded, and other committees. The results, reported in Figures A2 and A3, replicate the main findings. Moreover, the results are robust when issue type is operationalised using CAP coding (Figure A6).

A potential alternative explanation for the issue-specific gender gap is that it reflects gendered patterns of policy expertise rather than gendered norms. If parties disproportionately recruit women with professional experience in feminine-coded policy domains (and men with expertise in masculine-coded domains), or if legislators self-select into gendered career trajectories before entering parliament, the relationship between gender and speech participation could be spurious. To address this possibility, we re-estimate our models controlling for MPs' pre-parliamentary occupation.⁶ The results are reported in

⁶We manually extracted legislators' professional backgrounds from the biographical information avail-

Figure A4. The negative association between being a woman and participation in debates on masculine-coded issues remains substantively and statistically unchanged, suggesting that the lower propensity of women to speak on these issues cannot be explained solely by differences in prior professional expertise. By contrast, the positive association between being a woman and speaking on feminine-coded issues does not hold. These findings indicate that patterns of professional specialisation at least partly produce women's higher levels of participation in feminine-coded policy debates. In contrast, women's lower participation in masculine-coded debates seems to reflect mechanisms beyond differential expertise.

As a final robustness check, we assess whether our findings vary when committee proceedings are more time-constrained. Decree-law conversion bills provide a useful test: since they must be converted into law within 60 days, parties have arguably stronger reasons to control speech-making in committees. Yet we find results that closely mirror those of the main models, with effect sizes of similar magnitude. These findings support our interpretation that issue-gender gaps reflect gendered norms and expectations more than party gatekeeping.

The patterns documented above concern whether women speak. H3 shifts attention to where they speak. If visibility generates greater reputational returns, women who engage with masculine-coded issues may prefer to do so in the more visible plenary arena rather than in committee. The evidence provides little support for this argument. As shown in **Figure 4**, among MPs who delivered at least three speeches on a given bill, women are not more likely than men to choose the plenary over the committee when speaking on masculine-coded issues. Conversely, female legislators are significantly more likely to

able through the Italian lower house open data. We classified occupations into ten categories: bureaucrat, journalist, landowner/industrialist, lawyer/judge, manager, manual worker, politician/trade union official, professional, teacher, and academic. Because occupational information is unavailable for 438 MP-term observations, we do not include this variable in our main specifications and instead use it only as a robustness check.

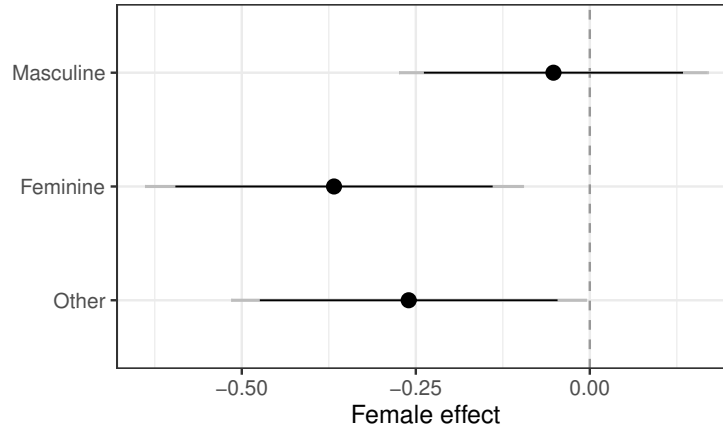


Figure 4. Total effect of gender on the percentage of speeches delivered in the plenary relative to committees across issues, 95% (grey)/90% (black).

speak in committee rather than in the plenary when the bill concerns a feminine-coded issue. As for H2, we find that the results for H3 are robust to an alternative operationalisation of issue type based on CAP coding.

To further probe these results, we explore whether this pattern varies across legislators. H3's logic may work better for highly active female MPs who have strong expertise, are prominent within their parties, or have a strong commitment to advancing women's representation. Such legislators may be better positioned to challenge gendered expectations surrounding masculine-coded issues and more likely to invest effort in highly visible parliamentary venues. The exploratory analyses reported in [Figure 5](#) provide some support for this expectation. Among the most active legislators, the estimated female effect becomes positive and statistically significant, indicating that highly engaged female MPs may indeed disproportionately allocate their efforts towards the most visible venue, i.e., the plenary.⁷ Given the relatively small number of highly active MPs, however, these results should be interpreted with caution. Still, they suggest that venue-selection effects might be concentrated among a limited set of critical actors.

⁷To perform this test, we employ MPs' level activity *in a specific bill debate*, allowing different legislators to emerge as critical actors in different policy debates.

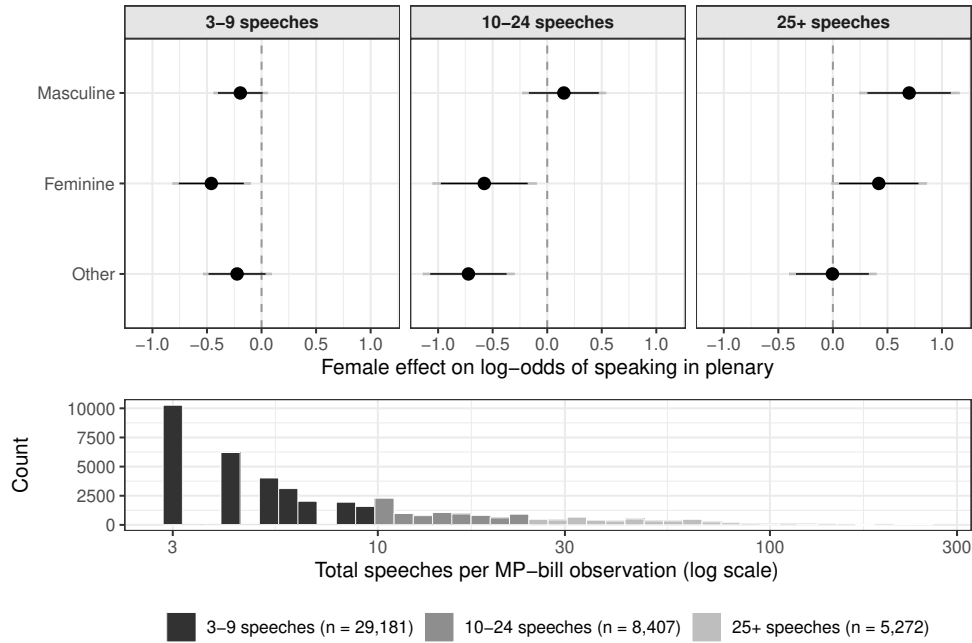


Figure 5. Total effect of gender on the percentage of speeches delivered in the plenary relative to committees across issues by number of speeches, 95% (grey)/90% (black), and distribution of number of speeches.

Conclusion

As Matthews (1960) emphasised in his seminal account of legislative life, parliamentary behaviour cannot be understood solely by examining written rules. Informal norms, routines, and shared expectations shape who participates, how legislators interact, and whose interventions are regarded as authoritative. These dynamics are particularly relevant in committees, where Matthews found that norms of seniority and apprenticeship shaped legislators' roles and opportunities for participation. For these norms, junior legislators should initially defer to more experienced colleagues, learn established practices, and gradually earn the authority to assume more active roles.

Following this approach, in this paper we examine how gender norms influence legislative speeches. While existing research has documented gender gaps in legislative

speeches on the parliamentary floor, we know less about gender dynamics in legislative committees. Leveraging the lower degree of party control in committees, our analyses investigate whether women's lower participation in parliamentary debates, especially on masculine issues, could be due to party gatekeeping or broader parliamentary norms, theorising how these norms might shape legislative behaviour. By comparing men and women debating the same legislative proposals, we assessed whether gender affects access to committee debates.

Our findings show that committee speechmaking is gendered. At the aggregate level, women and men are equally likely to join committee debates and, once they enter a debate, they do not speak less frequently – in clear contrast with the floor, where women participate less than men. However, this aggregate equality conceals substantial variation across policy domains. Women speak less frequently when committees discuss masculine-coded bills (constitutional and home affairs, foreign affairs, defence, the budget, finance, and transport), whereas the opposite pattern emerges for feminine-coded bills (education/culture and social affairs/health). Notably our additional tests suggest that women's higher participation in debates on feminine-coded issues is largely accounted for by their pre-parliamentary occupations. In contrast, their lower participation on masculine-coded issues persists once professional backgrounds are held constant. In other words, the former pattern is consistent with specialisation, while the latter points to gendered norms. We do not find support for the expectation that women allocate their interventions on masculine-coded bills towards the more visible plenary arena. However, exploratory analyses suggest that this pattern exists among highly active MPs.

Our findings raise a number of questions that future research could address. Because committee proceedings are published only as brief summaries, we observe whether and how often MPs speak, but not what they say. Where full committee transcripts are available, future research could also examine the content and reception of women's inter-

ventions. Moreover, the Italian case provides a particularly suitable setting for identifying these mechanisms because party leaders exercise substantial control over plenary speaking time, while committee participation is comparatively less constrained by formal speaker-selection procedures. Future research should therefore assess whether these findings travel beyond Italy. Comparative studies could examine legislatures that differ in the strength of party control over floor speech, the autonomy of committees, the rules governing participation by non-members, and the gender composition of parliamentary groups and committees. Such analyses could establish whether issue-specific gender gaps in committee speech are stronger in highly party-centred systems or persist even where individual MPs enjoy greater autonomy. This would provide a fuller account of how informal gendered norms shape parliamentary voice and of the conditions under which they can be challenged.

Our results contribute to the literature in two ways. First, the article shifts attention from plenary debate to committees, showing that these less visible arenas are important for reproducing gendered norms. Second, by comparing the same activity across venues, the analyses help clarify how gendered expectations about competence operate throughout the parliamentary institution. Overall, the results support the idea that parliaments are gendered institutions and that formal gatekeeping power tends to amplify inequalities rooted in broader gendered norms and roles.

References

- André, A., S. Depauw, and S. Martin (2015). "Electoral Systems and Legislators' Constituency Effort: The Mediating Effect of Electoral Vulnerability". *Comparative Political Studies*, 48(4): pp. 464–496.
- Anzia, S. F. and C. R. Berry (2011). "The Jackie (and Jill) Robinson Effect: Why Do Congresswomen Outperform Congressmen?" *American Journal of Political Science*, 55(3): pp. 478–493.
- Bäck, H. and M. Debus (2019). "When Do Women Speak? A Comparative Analysis of the Role of Gender in Legislative Debates". *Political Studies*, 67(3): pp. 576–596.
- Bäck, H., M. Debus, and J. Müller (2014). "Who Takes the Parliamentary Floor? The Role of Gender in Speech-making in the Swedish *Riksdag*". *Political Research Quarterly*, 67(3): pp. 504–518.
- Ban, P., J. Grimmer, J. Kaslovsky, and E. West (2022). "How does the rising number of women in the US Congress change deliberation? Evidence from House Committee Hearings". *Quarterly Journal of Political Science*, 17(3): pp. 355–387.
- Bates, S. H. (2021). "Re-structuring parliamentary roles". *International Journal of Parliamentary Studies*, 1(1): pp. 22–46.
- Belluati, M., D. R. Piccio, and R. Sampugnaro (2020). "Women's access to the political sphere in Italy: when obstacles outdo opportunities". *Contemporary Italian Politics*, 12(3): pp. 278–286.
- Butler, D. M., E. Naurin, and P. Öhberg (2022). "Constituents ask female legislators to do more". *The Journal of Politics*, 84(4): pp. 2278–2282.
- Capano, G. and M. Giuliani (2001). *Parlamento e processo legislativo in Italia: continuità e mutamento*. Bologna: Il Mulino.

- Catalano, A. (2009). "Women Acting for Women? An Analysis of Gender and Debate Participation in the British House of Commons 2005–2007". *Politics & Gender*, 5(1): pp. 45–68.
- Cavalieri, A. and E. De Giorgi (2025). "Women's substantive representation under the Meloni government. Insights from a new dataset on parliamentary attention in Italy". *South European Society and Politics*, 30(1): pp. 181–193.
- Chappell, L. (2006). "Comparing Political Institutions: Revealing the Gendered "Logic of Appropriateness"". *Politics & Gender*, 2(2): pp. 223–235.
- Chaqués-Bonafont, L. and C. Cristancho (2022). "The gender divide in issue attention". *European Journal of Political Research*, 61(1): pp. 3–20.
- Childs, S. and M. L. Krook (2009). "Analysing women's substantive representation: From critical mass to critical actors". *Government and opposition*, 44(2): pp. 125–145.
- Clayton, A. and P. Zetterberg (2021). "Gender and Party Discipline: Evidence from Africa's Emerging Party Systems". *American Political Science Review*, 115(3): pp. 869–884.
- Curini, L., S. Decadri, A. Ferrara, S. Montanelli, F. Negri, and F. Periti (2024). "The Gender Gap in Issue Attention and Language Use within a Legislative Setting: An Application to the Italian Parliament (1948–2020)". *Politics & Gender*, 20(1): pp. 182–211.
- Driscoll, A. and M. L. Krook (2009). "Can There Be a Feminist Rational Choice Institutionalism? 1". *Politics & Gender*, 5(2): pp. 238–245.
- Espírito-Santo, A. and E. R. Sanches (2020). "Who gets what? The interactive effect of MPs' sex in committee assignments in Portugal". *Parliamentary Affairs*, 73(2): pp. 450–472.
- Fernandes, J. M., M. Goplerud, and M. Won (2019). "Legislative Bellwethers: The Role of Committee Membership in Parliamentary Debate". *Legislative Studies Quarterly*, 44(2): pp. 307–343.

- Funk, K. D., L. Morales, and M. M. Taylor-Robinson (2017). "The impact of committee composition and agendas on women's participation: Evidence from a legislature with near numerical equality". *Politics & Gender*, 13(2): pp. 253–275.
- Giannetti, D. and A. Pedrazzani (2016). "Rules and speeches: How parliamentary rules affect legislators' speech-making behavior". *Legislative Studies Quarterly*, 41(3): pp. 771–800.
- Giannetti, D., L. Pinto, and A. Pedrazzani (2016). "Setting Parliamentary Calendars: How Parties Allocate Time for Plenary Debates on Bills". *Political Studies*, 64(4): pp. 1016–1035.
- Gianniti, L. and N. Lupo (2023). *Corso di diritto parlamentare*. Bologna: Il Mulino.
- Heath, R., L. A. Schwindt-Bayer, and M. M. Taylor-Robinson (2005). "Women on the Sidelines: Women's Representation on Committees in Latin American Legislatures". *American Journal of Political Science*, 49(2): pp. 420–436.
- Ivanusch, C. (2023). "Issue Competition in Parliamentary Speeches? A Computer-based Content Analysis of Legislative Debates in the Austrian Nationalrat". *Legislative Studies Quarterly*, Online first.
- Josefsson, C. (2024). *Defending the Status Quo: On Adaptive Resistance to Electoral Gender Quotas*. Oxford University Press. ISBN: 978-0-19-778859-2.
- Kanter, R. M. (1977). "Some effects of proportions on group life: Skewed sex ratios and responses to token women". *American journal of Sociology*, 82(5): pp. 965–990.
- Kenny, M. (2007). "Gender, Institutions and Power: A Critical Review". *Politics*, 27(2): pp. 91–100.
- Kroeber, C. (2024). "Gendered Patterns of Committee Assignments—To What Extent Are Women in Parliamentary Party Groups Game Changers?" *Parliamentary Affairs*, 77(3): pp. 623–643.

- Krook, M. L. and D. Z. O'Brien (2012). "All the president's men? The appointment of female cabinet ministers worldwide". *The Journal of Politics*, 74(3): pp. 840–855.
- Lasorella, G. (2023). *Il Parlamento: regole e dinamiche*. Torino: Giapichelli.
- Lawless, J. L. (2015). "Female candidates and legislators". *Annual Review of Political Science*, 18(1): pp. 349–366.
- Mackay, F., M. Kenny, and L. Chappell (2010). "New Institutionalism Through a Gender Lens: Towards a Feminist Institutionalism?" *International Political Science Review*, 31(5): pp. 573–588.
- March, J. and J. Olsen (1989). *Rediscovering institutions the organizational basis of politics*. New York: Free Press.
- Martin, S., T. Saalfeld, and K. W. Strøm (2014). "Introduction". In: Martin, S., T. Saalfeld, and K. W. Strøm, eds. *The Oxford Handbook of Legislative Studies*. Oxford: Oxford University Press: pp. 1–23. ISBN: 978-0-19-965301-0.
- Matthews, D. (1960). *U.S. Senators and their world*. New York: Random House.
- Mayhew, D. R. (1974). *Congress: The Electoral Connection*. Second Edition. New Haven: Yale University Press. ISBN: 978-0-300-10587-2.
- Murray, R. and R. Sénac (2018). "Explaining Gender Gaps in Legislative Committees". *Journal of Women, Politics & Policy*, 39(3): pp. 310–335.
- O'Brien, D. Z. (2015). "Rising to the Top: Gender, Political Performance, and Party Leadership in Parliamentary Democracies". *American Journal of Political Science*, 59(4): pp. 1022–1039.
- Pansardi, P. and A. Pedrazzani (2023). "Do (strong) gender quotas make a difference? Multiple candidacies as a party gatekeeping strategy in Italy". *Party Politics*, 29(4): pp. 711–725.
- Pansardi, P. and L. Pinto (2020). "Gender penalty and electoral outcomes in the 2018 Italian elections". *Contemporary Italian Politics*, 12(3): pp. 300–313.

- Pansardi, P. and M. Vercesi (2017). "Party Gate-Keeping and Women's Appointment to Parliamentary Committees: Evidence from the Italian Case". *Parliamentary Affairs*, 70(1): pp. 62–83.
- Pearson, K. and L. Dancey (2011a). "Elevating Women's Voices in Congress: Speech Participation in the House of Representatives". *Political Research Quarterly*, 64(4): pp. 910–923.
- (2011b). "Speaking for the Underrepresented in the House of Representatives: Voicing Women's Interests in a Partisan Era". *Politics & Gender*, 7(4): pp. 493–519.
- Proksch, S.-O. and J. B. Slapin (2012). "Institutional Foundations of Legislative Speech". *American Journal of Political Science*, 56(3): pp. 520–537.
- Puwar, N. (2004). *Space Invaders: Race, Gender and Bodies Out of Place*. Oxford: Bloomsbury. ISBN: 978-1-85973-654-8.
- Schneider, M. C. and A. L. Bos (2023). "The Political Psychology of Gender". In: Huddy, L., D. O. Sears, J. S. Levy, and J. Jerit, eds. *The Oxford Handbook of Political Psychology*. Oxford University Press: p. 0. ISBN: 978-0-19-754130-2.
- Searing, D. (1994). *Westminster's world: understanding political roles*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press. ISBN: 0-674-95072-0.
- Sebők, M., Á. Máté, O. Ring, V. Kovács, and R. Lehoczki (2025). "Leveraging Open Large Language Models for Multilingual Policy Topic Classification: The Babel Machine Approach". *Social Science Computer Review*, 43(2): pp. 295–317.
- Strøm, K. (1997). "Rules, Reasons and Routines: Legislative Roles in Parliamentary Democracies". *The Journal of Legislative Studies*, 3(1): pp. 155–174.
- Waylen, G. (2014). "Informal institutions, institutional change, and gender equality". *Political Research Quarterly*, 67(1): pp. 212–223.
- Yin, Y. (2024). "Are women politicians outperformed by men? The impact of gender on legislative activity in Japan". *Social Science Quarterly*, 105(3): pp. 636–654.

Appendix

*Women's Speeches in Legislative Committees:
A Feminist Institutionalist Explanation*

Table of Contents

A	Descriptive statistics	A2
B	Full models	A3
C	Additional tests	A6
D	Robustness tests	A7

A Descriptive statistics

Table A1. Summary statistics for the variables used in the models.

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Spoke in committee	1,957,176	0.03	0.18	0.00	1
Spoke in plenary	1,957,176	0.03	0.18	0.00	1
N. speeches (committee)	1,957,176	0.17	2.25	0.00	226
N. speeches (plenary)	1,957,176	0.17	2.17	0.00	133
Female	1,957,176	0.35	0.48	0.00	1
Masculine-coded bill	1,957,176	0.56	0.50	0.00	1
Feminine-coded bill	1,957,176	0.19	0.40	0.00	1
Graduate degree	1,957,176	0.45	0.50	0.00	1
Rapporteur	1,957,176	0.00	0.04	0.00	1
Legislative office	1,957,176	0.22	0.42	0.00	1
Party office	1,957,176	0.37	0.48	0.00	1
Government office	1,957,176	0.10	0.30	0.00	1
Tenure (terms)	1,957,176	1.63	1.10	1.00	8
Party switcher	1,957,176	0.31	0.46	0.00	1
Single-member district	1,957,176	0.19	0.39	0.00	1
Electoral vulnerability	1,957,176	0.72	0.28	0.03	1
Age (years)	1,957,176	44.25	10.83	25.00	74

B Full models

Table A2. Female main effect on access and intensity (H1)

	Spoke (plenary) (1) Logit	Spoke (committee) (2) Logit	N speeches (plenary) (3) Neg. Bin.	N speeches (committee) (4) Neg. Bin.
Female	-0.275*** (0.078)	-0.065 (0.076)	-0.195*** (0.061)	-0.077 (0.054)
Graduate degree	-0.142* (0.080)	-0.025 (0.074)	0.121* (0.069)	0.103* (0.058)
Rapporteur	6.91*** (0.219)	6.11*** (0.224)	1.50*** (0.072)	1.40*** (0.059)
Legislative office	0.308*** (0.087)	0.782*** (0.074)	0.191*** (0.066)	0.385*** (0.056)
Party office	0.551*** (0.079)	0.599*** (0.066)	0.089 (0.060)	0.072 (0.050)
Government office	-0.444*** (0.133)	0.005 (0.158)	0.527*** (0.129)	0.286*** (0.093)
Electoral vulnerability	-0.504*** (0.141)	-0.541*** (0.128)	0.187* (0.112)	-0.063 (0.110)
Tenure	0.001 (0.050)	0.018 (0.039)	0.084*** (0.029)	0.028 (0.024)
SMD	-0.711*** (0.099)	-0.256*** (0.097)	-0.267*** (0.063)	-0.079 (0.070)
Switcher	0.194** (0.085)	0.247*** (0.082)	0.004 (0.077)	0.058 (0.070)
Age (centred)	-0.0001 (0.004)	0.009** (0.004)	-0.002 (0.003)	0.006* (0.003)
Observations	1,824,336	1,957,176	64,237	65,793
Log-Likelihood	-218,353.1	-244,302.2	-154,480.5	-159,794.3
Pseudo R ²	0.215	0.152	0.116	0.095
Bill fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Two-way clustered SEs (deputy, bill). Bill, party (PPG) and committee FE included; FE coefficients omitted.

Table A3. Female $\times$ Issue on committee access and intensity (H2)

	Spoke (committee) (1) Logit	N speeches (committee) (2) Neg. Bin.
Female	-0.075 (0.089)	-0.097 (0.085)
Graduate degree	-0.025 (0.074)	0.106* (0.058)
Rapporteur	6.11*** (0.225)	1.40*** (0.058)
Legislative office	0.782*** (0.074)	0.382*** (0.055)
Party office	0.599*** (0.066)	0.068 (0.050)
Government office	0.005 (0.158)	0.288*** (0.094)
Electoral vulnerability	-0.541*** (0.128)	-0.066 (0.110)
Tenure	0.018 (0.039)	0.026 (0.024)
SMD	-0.257*** (0.097)	-0.084 (0.069)
Switcher	0.247*** (0.082)	0.057 (0.069)
Age (centred)	0.009** (0.004)	0.005* (0.003)
Female $\times$ Masculine	-0.163* (0.091)	-0.147 (0.104)
Female $\times$ Feminine	0.308*** (0.106)	0.297** (0.141)
Observations	1,957,176	65,793
Log-Likelihood	-244,132.8	-159,646.7
Pseudo R ²	0.152	0.096
Bill fixed effects	✓	✓

Reference category for Issue is 'Other'. Two-way clustered SEs (deputy, bill). Bill, party (PPG) and committee FE included.

Table A4. Female $\times$ Issue on venue choice (H3)

	Share plenary (1)
Female	-0.117 (0.149)
Graduate degree	-0.064 (0.123)
Rapporteur	0.111 (0.197)
Legislative office	-0.549*** (0.113)
Party office	0.106 (0.110)
Government office	0.018 (0.225)
Electoral vulnerability	0.416** (0.194)
Tenure	0.026 (0.060)
SMD	-0.423** (0.199)
Switcher	-0.070 (0.144)
Age (centred)	-0.008 (0.007)
Female $\times$ Masculine	0.358** (0.182)
Female $\times$ Feminine	0.041 (0.208)
Observations	41,927
Log-Likelihood	-108,816.0
Pseudo R ²	0.723
Bill fixed effects	✓

Fractional logit weighted by total speeches; sample restricted to MPs with ≥ 3 total speeches. Two-way clustered SEs (deputy, bill).

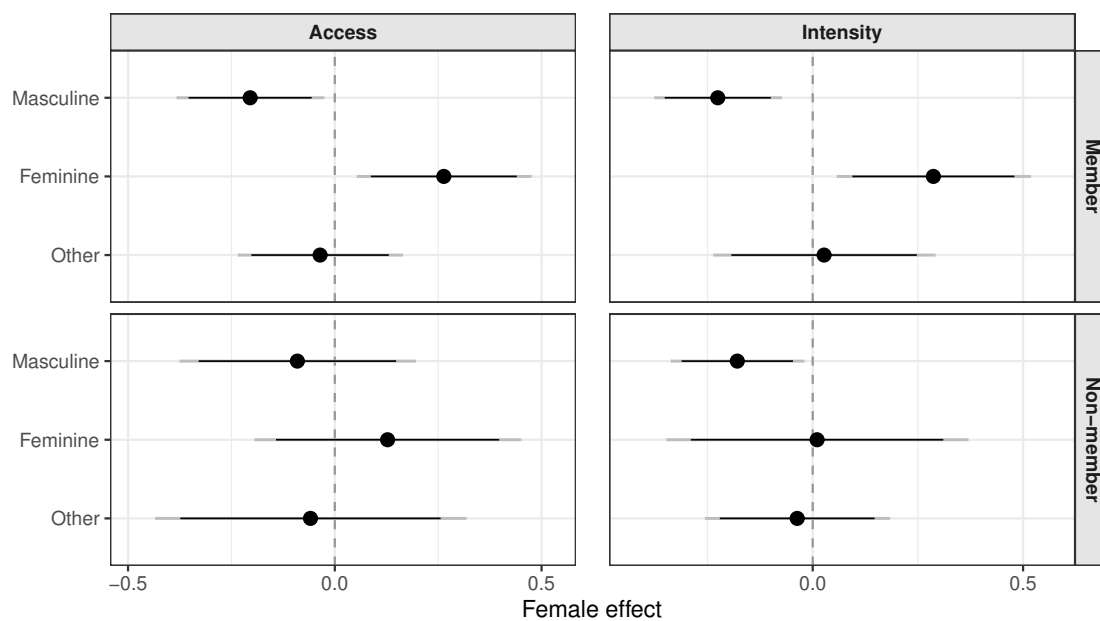


Figure A1. Total effect of gender on speeches in committees across issues by committee membership, 95% (grey)/90% (black), and distribution of number of speeches.

C Additional tests

D Robustness tests

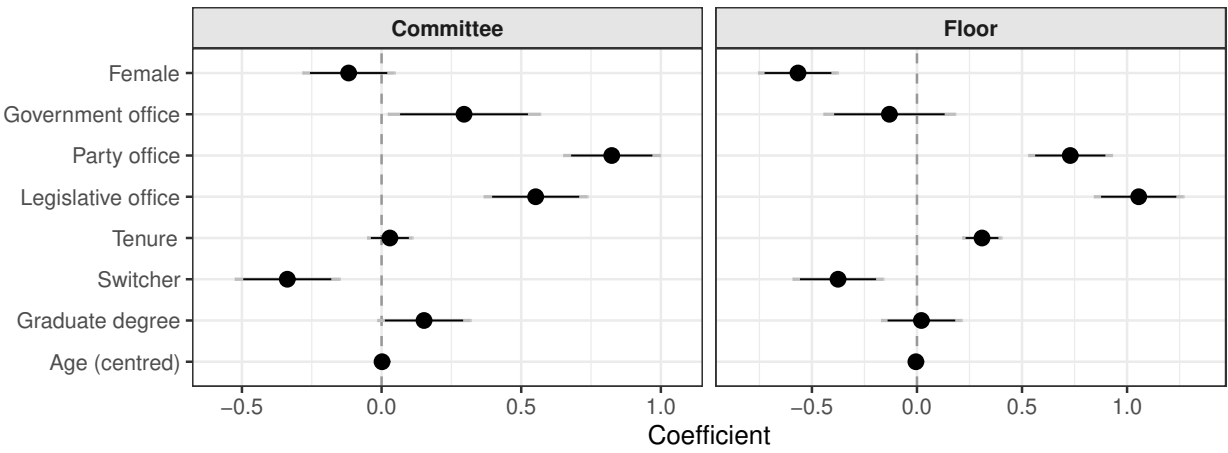


Figure A2. Gender and speeches in committees (MP-level), 95% (grey)/90% (black).

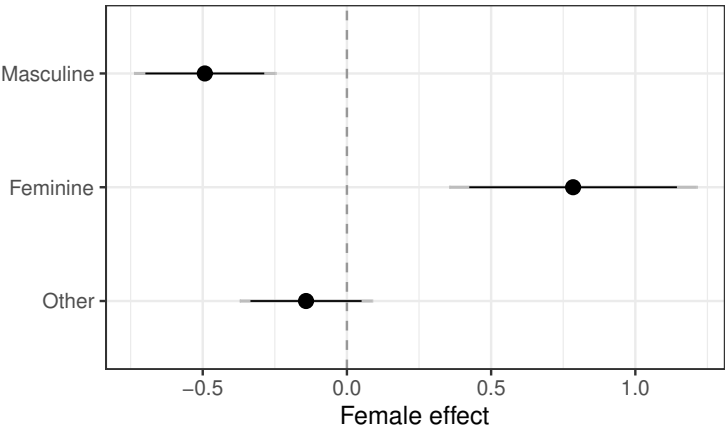


Figure A3. Total effect of gender on speeches in committees across issues (MP-level), 95% (grey)/90% (black).

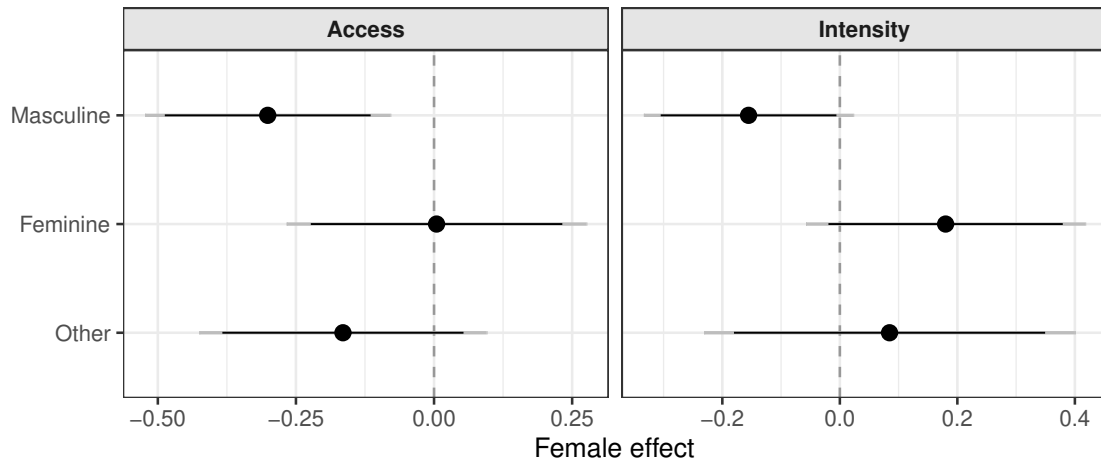


Figure A4. Total effect of gender on speeches in committees across issues (controlling for pre-parliamentary occupation), 95% (grey)/90% (black).

Table A5. Mapping of Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) major topics to the masculine, feminine, and other issue categories.

Category	CAP major topics
Masculine	1 Macroeconomics, 10 Transportation, 15 Domestic Commerce, 16 Defense, 18 Foreign Trade, 19 International Affairs, 20 Government Operations
Feminine	3 Health, 6 Education, 13 Social Welfare, 23 Culture
Other	2 Civil Rights, 4 Agriculture, 5 Labor, 7 Environment, 8 Energy, 9 Immigration, 12 Law and Crime, 14 Housing, 17 Technology, 21 Public Lands

Table A6. CAP Babel Machine coding vs. committee-referral coding of bill topic.

Babel coding	Committee assignment			Total
	Masculine	Feminine	Other	
Masculine	675 (85.0%)	29 (3.7%)	90 (11.3%)	794
Feminine	36 (13.3%)	227 (83.8%)	8 (3.0%)	271
Other	275 (39.1%)	72 (10.2%)	356 (50.6%)	703
Total	986	328	454	1,768

Note: Overall agreement: 1,258 / 1,768 bills (71.2%).

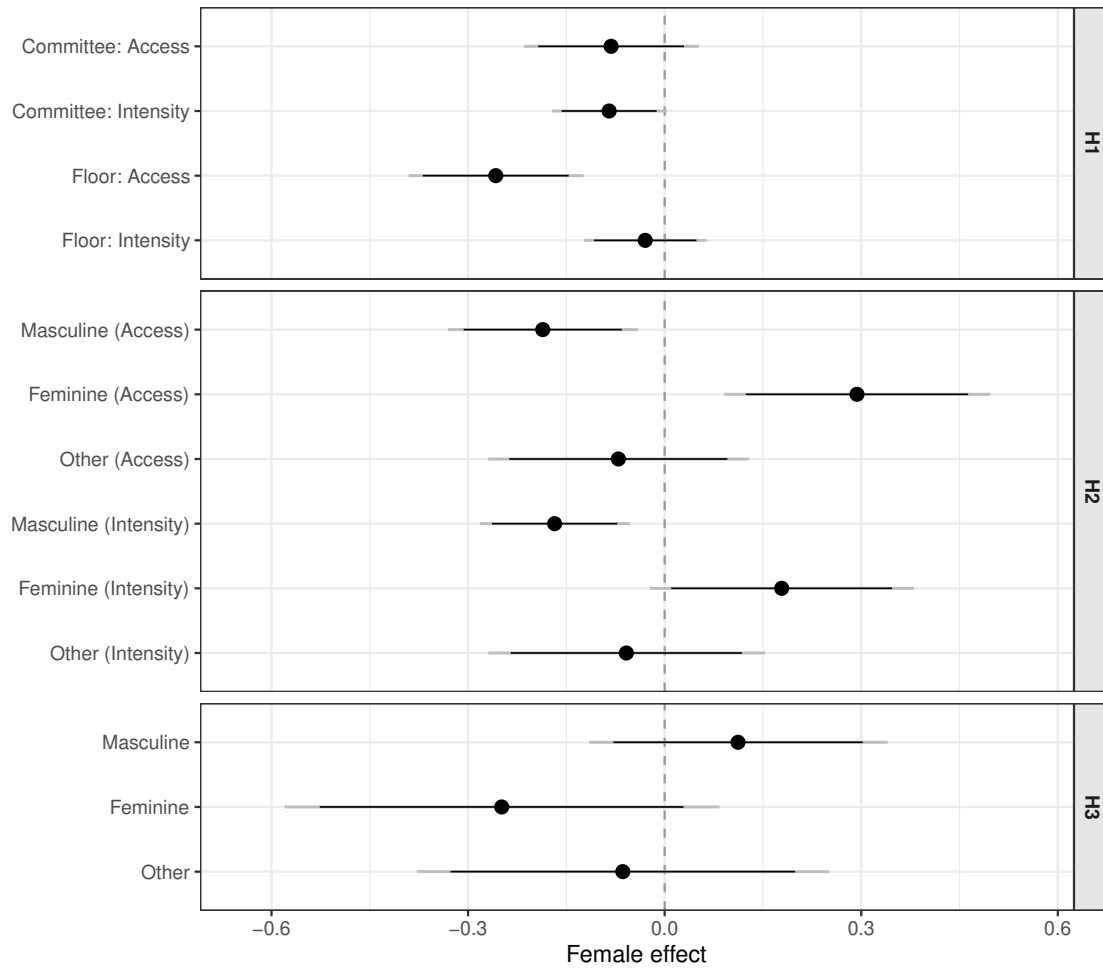


Figure A5. Effect of gender in law decrees subsample, 95% (grey)/90% (black).

Table A7. CAP LLM (Claude) coding vs. committee-referral coding of bill topic.

CAP coding	Committee assignment			Total
	Masculine	Feminine	Other	
Masculine	739 (87.9%)	11 (1.3%)	91 (10.8%)	841
Feminine	34 (10.9%)	265 (85.2%)	12 (3.9%)	311
Other	213 (34.6%)	52 (8.4%)	351 (57.0%)	616
Total	986	328	454	1,768

Note: Overall agreement: 1,355 / 1,768 bills (76.6%).

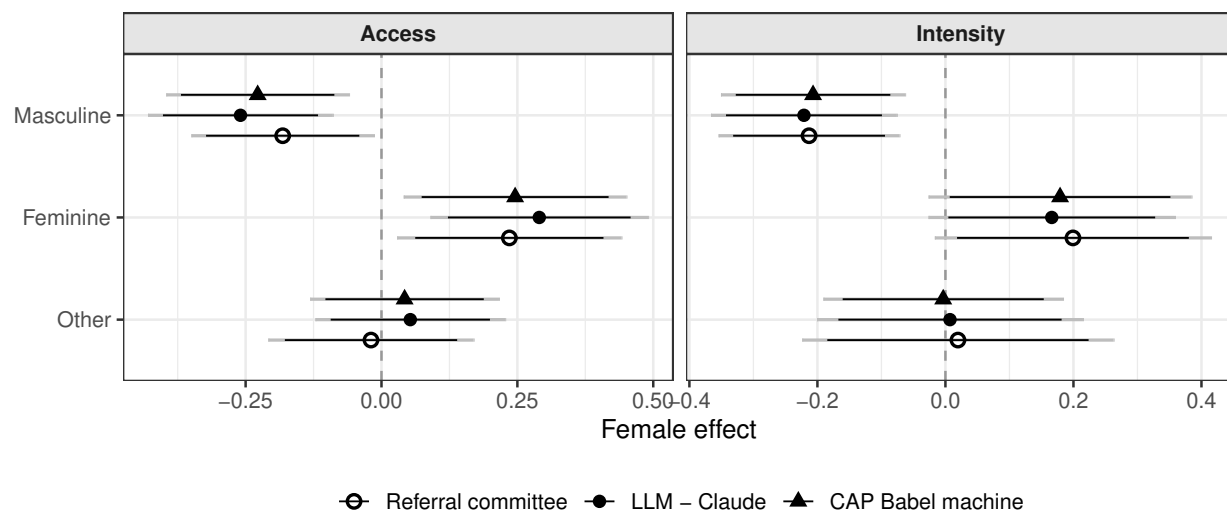


Figure A6. Total effect of gender on speeches in committees across issues (CAP coding), 95% (grey)/90% (black).

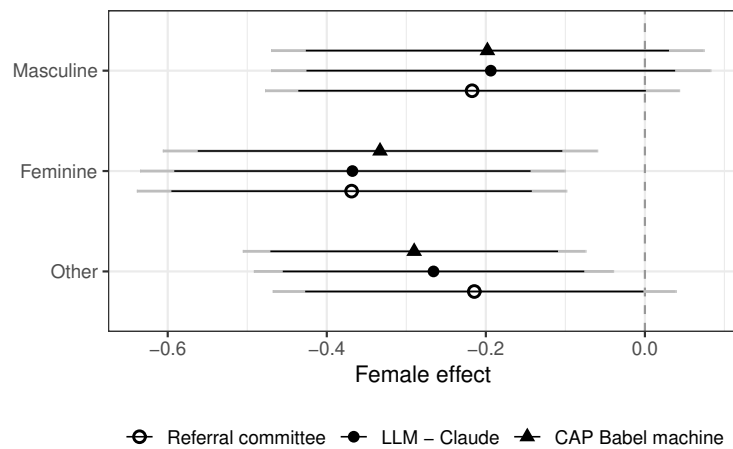


Figure A7. Total effect of gender on the percentage of speeches delivered in the plenary across issues (CAP coding), 95% (grey)/90% (black).